Participating in group work

Practical guide for students | D08-ST

Group work involves sharing ideas, listening, making decisions and completing tasks together. Working in English can make these activities more demanding. These strategies can help you contribute and work effectively with others.

1. Check what the group needs to do

Before starting, make sure you understand the task, the expected outcome and the deadline. Ask questions such as:

- "What do we need to produce?"
- "Are we comparing the options or choosing one?"
- "What do we need to finish today?"

Briefly restate the task in your own words so the group can check that everyone has the same understanding.

2. Agree on roles and ways of working

Discuss how you will divide the work, communicate and bring everyone's contributions together. You could agree on:

- Who will complete each part and by when.
- How you will share files and updates.
- How you will make decisions.
- When you will check progress.

Choose roles that let everyone contribute to the subject content. If you regularly take notes, for example, also look for opportunities to explain ideas or present findings.

3. Prepare something to contribute

If you know the topic in advance, prepare a few points, questions or examples. Note down useful subject vocabulary and any evidence you want to discuss. Short notes are usually easier to use during a discussion than a complete script.

You could prepare one idea or recommendation, a reason or example that supports it, and a question for the group.

4. Use simple phrases to join the discussion

You do not need to wait until you can express an idea perfectly. Start with your main point, then explain it. For example:

- "I'd like to add something."
- "My suggestion is … because …"
- "Could we also consider …?"
- "I agree with that point, but I'm concerned about …"
- "Could I finish my point first?"

If the discussion moves too quickly, ask the group to pause or return to a point: “Can we go back to the second option? I have a question about it.”

5. Help the group build shared understanding

Check meaning when something is unclear, and give others time to explain their ideas. You can:

- Summarise a decision: “So, we’ve agreed to compare both options using these three criteria?”
- Ask for clarification: “When you say ‘cost’, do you mean the starting cost or the ongoing cost?”
- Invite another contribution: “What do you think about this option?”
- Use a diagram, calculation or written note to explain a difficult point.

Where appropriate and consistent with course requirements, use shared languages or translation tools to clarify meaning. Make sure everyone can understand the ideas and decisions that the group needs to use.

6. Check progress and address difficulties early

Before finishing a meeting, confirm what has been decided, who will do each task and when you will meet again. If there is a problem, describe it specifically and suggest a practical next step:

- “We still need the data analysis before we can write the conclusion. Can we agree on a time for sharing it?”
- “I’m finding it difficult to contribute when several people speak at once. Could we take turns?”

If difficulties continue, contact your teacher before they affect the final submission. Explain what has happened and what the group has already tried.

7. Example comparing two business proposals

Your group must recommend one of two proposals using cost, customer demand and risk. Before the meeting, you prepare a short comparison of the costs. During the discussion, you say:

“I think Proposal B has a lower starting cost, but its ongoing costs are higher. Could we compare the total cost over one year?”

You show your calculation and ask a group member to check it. Before finishing, the group records its decision and agrees who will draft each part of the recommendation.

8. Quick checklist

☐ I understand the task and what the group must produce.

☐ We have agreed on responsibilities and deadlines.

☐ I have prepared ideas, questions or evidence.

☐ I ask for clarification and help others contribute.

☐ We record decisions and check progress.

☐ I raise difficulties early.

9. When to seek further support

Ask your teacher for help if task requirements or individual responsibilities remain unclear, or if participation problems continue. Seek support promptly if you experience exclusion or discriminatory behaviour.

If using English regularly prevents you from contributing, ask about language support, academic skills workshops or opportunities to practise discussion skills.

10.Supporting sources

RMIT University. (n.d.). Group work: Getting started. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports agreeing on task requirements, allocating responsibilities, setting deadlines, choosing communication tools and recording meeting outcomes.

RMIT University. (n.d.). Group work: Doing the work. Learning Lab. Open resource

Supports inclusive discussion, progress checks, recording decisions, addressing problems early and seeking help when the group cannot resolve them.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Group Work/Projects. Open resource

Supports preparing specific questions, entering discussions, clarifying meaning, returning to earlier topics, inviting opinions and contributing through written or digital channels.